in the public sphere has influenced this article's thesis that gendered identities are used in particular ways to provide legitimacy and support for political narratives.

These are all critical contributions to academic discussions on Myanmar, but as they are primarily focused on the gender relations within Burman, as opposed to minority communities, there is a lack of scholarly attention on the impact of gender relations within minority communities in Myanmar. As a result, they are blind to the gendered roots of political violence in Kachin State, and this is limiting our understanding of conflict and possible solutions to it. This chapter, then, aims to add to the body of knowledge in Myanmar studies by bringing a new analysis to the debate on intrastate conflicts by considering the impact of gender and political economy on the war in Kachin State.

ANALYSING THE KACHIN CONFLICT WITH A FEMINIST POLITICAL ECONOMY METHOD

In order to understand the relationship between poverty and violence, Jacqui True's recent work on the political economy of violence against women is important. True has put forward a convincing thesis that draws out the relationship between materiality and insecurity by examining the connection between women's access to productive resources, power and justice, and gender-based violence (2010, 2012). This framework renders 'strategic sites' visible, where the nexus of political and economic processes coalesce towards "heightening the conditions for and increasing the extent of violence against women" (True 2012, p. 19).

True argues that all forms of violence have a material basis (2010, p. 30), meaning that violence against women must be contextualized in gendered structures of poverty and political exclusion. In other words, it is not poverty per se that determines women's levels of insecurity, but their relative level of inequality vis-à-vis men in their community (True 2012, p. 18). This means that socio-economic and political inequality as experienced by Kachin women, in both times of conflict and peace, detrimentally impacts their access to justice, and economic and political opportunities, resulting in these women being unable to effectively challenge or question discrimination, and thus, making them more vulnerable to abuse.

Although this framework needs to be taken further in certain areas to